misapplied by Ludovico to the ancient sea-port of Nagapattinam, on the delta of the Cauvery (Kaveri) River, rather than the region. ‘The city is very large,’ he writes in his *Itinerario*. ‘They gather a great quantity of rice, and it is the route to very large countries. There are many Moorish merchants here who go and come for their merchandise. No spices of any description grow here, but plenty of fruits.’

From Nagapattinam the two travellers sailed first to Ceylon (now Sri Lanka), and then back up the Indian coast to Bengal before continuing on to Burma and beyond. They spent the early summer of 1505 moving from one spice island to another before turning back with a rich cargo of spices and silks. At Malacca they chartered a large vessel which Ludovico terms a *giuncu* – in other words, a junk, showing the continuing influence of the China trade – and in June they sailed back across the Bay of Bengal to ‘the said city of Cioromandel’.

Ludovico was now worried that his Muslim disguise had been penetrated. He looked for an opportunity to escape, and when he and Cazazioner returned by sea to Calicut, Ludovico seized the chance to desert his friend and join the Portuguese.

In March 1506 Ludovico fought alongside his new allies in a sea-battle off Cannanore (Kannur) in which eleven Portuguese ships dispersed 209 enemy vessels of the Zamorin of Calicut. He was then caught up in the four-month siege of Cannanore, in which the firepower of the Portuguese again made the difference, enabling them to repulse the assaults of thousands of Nair warriors. It is recorded that what saved the garrison from starvation at a critical point of the siege was a mass of lobsters washed ashore, taken as a sign that God was on their side. Ludovico’s courage in battle won him a knighthood, after which he worked for the Portuguese as a ‘factor’, or trader, in Cochin for three years before returning to Europe.